THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE WAS not plasticine when my generation read it at school. But, by college, we'd begun to play with it like clay, because it seemed less of an imported toy. The question of irreverence to the Queen's English was catching on when I practised copywriting. But *The Line of Mercy* by Tarun Tejpal may well be the best bedside reading for the eternal Queen Elizabeth II. She'll be fascinated with the writer's facility with a language she must know better but hasn't dared to make as malleable. Every other line of this opus fills the reader with wonder at the mind of a provincial Chandigarh boy who has married his Naipaul with Dostoevsky and Marquez with Ferlinghetti to create with his bewildering new vocabulary of images a rebellious new highway of e e cummings and goings. No writer I've read has been there in language and subject matter.

The story, or rather the cataract of stories, are pivoted inside a prison, weighted by first-hand research because destiny and posterity connived to lock up Tejpal to excavate out of him an epic of woe, spiked with a humour that laughs aloud at itself. Now that 527 pages acquit Tejpal, how will the world stand up in bed for a standing ovation when they read it?

Beyond its soaring scale and scope and its masterful prose, what may be most impressive about Tejpal's novel is its utter originality. In a publishing landscape awash with crony-and-commerce-hyped books that are tediously banal and derivative, *The Line of Mercy* is unlike anything else. Not just in the limited sphere of Indian writing, but by the widest global standards. I would say it is set to be a milestone classic of literature—a book that opens up new material in dazzling new ways. A book that rips out from concealed cupboards, the flesh—not the skeleton—of lost and buried stories and, with the airing of each, unblinkingly demands that every reader re-examine their prejudices, cheap opinions and woeful ignorances.

Tracking the debris of broken lives and screwball dreams, frantic fantasies and desperate schemes, *Mercy* does what only a handful of books in every age do: reveal the immorality of man-made moralities. *The Line of Mercy* is the work of not just a great novelist but also of a philosopher, stand-up comic, street-brawler, insurrectionist, poet and bandmaster. And, above all, a lover.

An obvious triumph is that for all the sprawling grimness of the material, the book is written in a voice marvellously rich with irony, self-mockery, acid wit, slapstick scenes, joyous burlesque—as another writer recently said about it, there is "more mojo per page than people manage in a tome". So, again and again, you find your ribs tickled and your heart wrung at the same moment. Through every tragedy peeps the petticoat of farce, and every uniform of pomp and propriety has its flies wide open. For example, one set-piece, where the love-maddened young boy, Bobo, meets three drunk labourers late at night, has the timeless resonance of a Shakespearean aside: comic relief conveying cosmic truths.

The novel is littered with such scenes. Moments of epiphany, of hitting a mirror, and turning to find mirrors everywhere—even in the dark. In fact, what is a wonder is how, for this thick a book, of 765 pages, every line is chiselled to sing. There is no fluff, all is resonance, all is meaning. The sheer number of notes the book strikes would do justice to a symphony. And the cast of characters would rock Dickens and Fellini back on their heels. From Jogen Juggler to Half-doctor Gomes, Bichchoo to Aslam, Godwin to the Phantom brothers, the lawyers Falkar and Phalkar, and a score more—each could carry a novel, each is a window and a metaphor into the ecstatic-misery of the human condition.

At one point, Tejpal writes: "The land of the forsaken is forever marooned in an age of iron. Iron iron iron. Cold and heavy and clanking. And you feel it and you hear it all day. On your hands and in your ears... The country inside the iron bars was no different from the sales pitch



THE LINE OF MERCY
by Tarun J. Tejpal
HarperCollins India
₹899; 768 pages

WITHOUT DECLARING IT ONCE, THE BOOK MAKES IT CLEAR THAT THE PURE KERNEL INSIDE OF SO MUCH CRIME IS MADE OF URGENT LOVE AND DESIRE, GONE WRONG OR MADE TO GO WRONG